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INDIA, PAKISTAN URGED TO SHOW RESTRAINT

■ UAE CALLS ON BOTH NATIONS TO AVOID FURTHER ESCALATION ■ NEW DELHI STRESSES ACTION WAS FOCUSED AND MEASURED ■ ISLAMABAD SAYS WORLD MUST HOLD INDIA ACCOUNTABLE

ABU DHABI

Deadly clashes between India and Pakistan prompted concern and calls for restraint from around the world yesterday.

Shaikh Abdullah Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs, has called on the two nations to exercise restraint, de-escalate tensions, and avoid further escalation that could threaten regional and international peace.

Shaikh Abdullah stressed the importance of heeding the voices calling for dialogue and mutual understanding to prevent military escalation, strengthen stability in South Asia, and avoid further regional tensions.

Diplomats worldwide have also piled pressure on leaders of the two nations to step back.

"The world cannot afford a military confrontation between India and Pakistan," the spokesman for UN chief Antonio Guterres, Stephane Dujarric, said in a statement.

US President Donald Trump



■ People look at a damaged part of an aircraft in Wuyan, near Srinagar, yesterday.

told reporters in Washington he hoped that the fighting "ends very quickly". The EU called on both nations to act immediately to de-escalate.

Concern poured in, includ-

ing from China — a mutual neighbour of both nations — as well as from Britain, France, Germany and Russia, while airlines have cancelled, diverted or rerouted flights.

Earlier yesterday, India and Pakistan exchanged heavy artillery fire along their frontier after New Delhi launched deadly missile strikes on its neighbour, in the worst vio-

lence between the nuclear-armed nations in two decades.

38 deaths reported

At least 38 deaths were reported, with Islamabad saying 26 civilians were killed by the Indian strikes and firing along the border, and New Delhi adding at least 12 dead from Pakistani shelling.

India's Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said the strikes were a "carefully planned" operation that exercised New Delhi's "right to respond".

The Indian army said "justice is served", reporting nine "terrorist camps" had been destroyed, with New Delhi adding that its actions "have been focused, measured and non-escalatory in nature".

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif condemned the Indian operation as a "cowardly attack." Pakistan's National Security Committee (NSC) which convened for an urgent meeting in the capital Islamabad after the strikes by India said the world must hold its neighbour "accountable", according to a statement.

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